

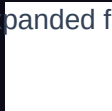
Our Methodology

These predictions are built on a combination of: current squad depth and quality, qualifying form (last 18 months), historical tournament performance, tactical identity and flexibility, and key player form and fitness heading into 2026. We've tracked every qualifying campaign and assessed 48 squads

WC2026-EMPIRE

Tournament Structure

World Cup 2026 is the first 48-team World Cup. The format: 12 groups of 4, top 2 from each group plus 8 best 3rd-place finishers advance (32 total). Then: Round of 32, Round of 16, Quarter-Finals, Semi-Finals, 3rd Place Play-Off, Final. The expanded format gives more teams a chance — more upsets, more dramatic moments.



WC2026 Ultimate Predictions Pack

Full tournament predictions — all 48 teams, full bracket, upset alerts

\$9.99

Top Contenders — Tier 1 (Can Win the Tournament)

■ ■ France — Favourites

Squad Grade: A+

The most complete squad in world football. Mbappé at peak (27 at tournament time), Camavinga and Tchouaméni controlling midfield, Théo Hernandez bombing from left back. Didier Deschamps' system is brutally efficient — they win even when not playing well.

- Mbappé-Dembélé-Giroud/Kolo Muani front line — terrifying
- Midfield: Camavinga, Tchouaméni, Rabiot/Guendouzi
- Best defensive depth of any team
- Won 2018, Final 2022 — tournament experience embedded

■ ■ Argentina — Holders

Squad Grade: A

Can they do it twice? Messi will be 38 — this is almost certainly his last World Cup. De Paul, Fernández, and MacAllister form an elite midfield. Lautaro Martínez leads the line. The emotional stakes will drive this team.

- Messi's last World Cup = maximum motivation
- MacAllister (Liverpool) has grown into world-class
- Proven winners — know how to grind through tournaments
- Enzo Fernández is one of the best midfielders on earth

■ ■ Brazil — Always Dangerous

Squad Grade: A-

Brazil always arrive as favourites and yet haven't won since 2002. Vinicius Jr and Rodrygo are devastating. Endrick arrives as a teenager with LaLiga experience. New manager has settled the defensive instability that cost them in 2022.

- Vinicius Jr — best winger in the world when on form
- Rodrygo provides the perfect complement
- Deep squad — can rotate without losing quality
- Defensive stability improved significantly

■ ■ Portugal — Dark Horse Favourite

Squad Grade: A-

Post-Ronaldo dependency, Portugal is actually stronger. Bruno Fernandes orchestrates everything. Pedro (Barcelona) leads the line. Rafael Leão adds pace. Ruben Dias anchors the defence.

- Pedro — one of the best strikers in the world
- Bruno Fernandes freed from Ronaldo's shadow
- Leão adds direct pace and flair on the left
- Ruben Dias — best defensive leader in Portugal history

■ ■ Germany — Hosts of 2006, Redemption Arc

Squad Grade: B+

Germany's squad is rebuilding but Florian Wirtz has emerged as a generational talent. Musiala is technically elite. They play in USA/Canada/Mexico — familiar Americas conditions.

- Wirtz — best young German player since Özil
- Musiala adds creativity and close control
- Strong domestic motivation after 2018/2022 group stage exits
- New coach has rebuilt team identity

Our Full Bracket Prediction

Stage	Team 1	Result	Team 2
Semi-Final 1	🇫🇷 France	2–1	🇵🇹 Portugal
Semi-Final 2	🇦🇷 Argentina	1–1 (4-3 pens)	🇧🇷 Brazil
3rd Place	🇵🇹 Portugal	2–0	🇧🇷 Brazil
■ FINAL	■ France	2–1 AET	■ Argentina

Golden Boot Prediction

Place	Player	Team	Expected Goals
■ 1st	Kylian Mbappé	🇫🇷 France	7–9 goals
■ 2nd	Pedro	🇵🇹 Portugal	6–8 goals
■ 3rd	Vinicius Jr	🇧🇷 Brazil	5–7 goals
4th	Lautaro Martínez	🇦🇷 Argentina	5–6 goals
5th	Erling Haaland*	🇳🇴 Norway*	5–6 goals

*Norway qualification pending as of publication.

Top 5 Upset Alerts ■

■ USA beat England in the Group Stage

Home crowd + revenge for 1950 — America's most famous World Cup upset was beating England 1-0 in Brazil. They can do it again.

■ Japan eliminate a top-8 nation

They beat Germany AND Spain in Qatar. They will do it again. Japan vs France in the Round of 16 would be appointment TV.

■ Morocco reach the Semi-Finals again

They did it in Qatar. Same coach, older squad, more experience. The template is set.

■ Saudi Arabia beat a South American giant

They beat Argentina in Qatar. They love a famous scalp. Don't put them against Brazil in a must-win.

■ An African team wins the tournament

2026 gives Africa more spots (9 teams). Morocco, Senegal, or Nigeria reaching the Final is not impossible.